Modular construction of sound-and-complete simplifiers for varieties of semi-rings

Ohad Kammar, LFCS, University of Edinburgh and
Amaury Mazoyer, École Normale Supérieure de Lyon



26th IFIP Working Group 2.11
October 13, 2026, Niagara-on-the-Lake, Ontario, Canada



Algebraic simplification

represent **equivalence classes** of expressions

$$1 + 3x + 6y + (-1) \in [0, 3, 3] \ni 3y + 3x + 3y \qquad \text{(integers mod } \begin{cases} \text{commutativity} \\ \text{associativity} \\ \text{neutrality} \end{cases} \text{)}$$

$$\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N} \ni [a, n, k] \qquad \text{represents} \qquad a + nx + ky$$

Algebraic simplification

represent **equivalence classes** of expressions

$$1 + 3\mathsf{x} + 6\mathsf{y} + (-1) \in [0, 3, 3] \ni 3\mathsf{y} + 3\mathsf{x} + 3\mathsf{y} \qquad \text{(integers mod } \begin{cases} \text{commutativity} \\ \text{associativity} \\ \text{neutrality} \end{cases} \text{)}$$

$$\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N} \ni [a, n, k] \qquad \text{represents} \qquad a + n\mathsf{x} + k\mathsf{y}$$

Robust code generation

- **Partial evaluation** (Carette et al., 2009, tagless final)
  esp. **partially-static data** structures (Yallop et al., 2018, frex)
- Rôte-proof **synthesis** (Allais et al., 2025, Agda/Idris frex)
- Program **synthesis** (Shepherd et al., 2026)

Algebraic simplification

represent **equivalence classes** of expressions

$$1 + 3x + 6y + (-1) \in [0, 3, 3] \ni 3y + 3x + 3y \qquad \text{(integers mod } \begin{cases} \text{commutativity} \\ \text{associativity} \\ \text{neutrality} \end{cases} \text{)}$$

$$\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N} \ni [a, n, k] \qquad \text{represents} \qquad a + nx + ky$$

Extensions beyond ordinary algebra

- **NbE** with algebraic structure (Corbyn et al., 2022)
- 2nd and 3rd **Futamura** projections of **System T** (Brown, 2027, thesis)
  uses frex for **second-order** algebraic theories

Modern algebra's core idea:

Theorem (extensional normalisation)

Let:

- $\mathcal{T}$ *be an algebraic theory;*
- $A = \langle \underline{A}, A[\![-]\!] \rangle$ *be a free* $\mathcal{T}$*-model with variables from* X*, i.e.: and* $\mathrm{var} : X \to \underline{A}$*.*

Then:

an equation $X \vdash t \equiv u$ *is* **provable** *in* $\mathcal{T}$	$\iff$	A **validates** *it* $A[\![t]\!]\,\mathrm{var} = A[\![u]\!]\,\mathrm{var}$

Takeaway

computable/effective representation of free models

$\Downarrow$

normalisation/algebraic simplification **procedures**

Modern algebra's core idea:

Theorem (extensional normalisation)

Let:

- $\mathcal{T}$ *be an algebraic theory;*
- $A = \langle \underline{A}, A[\![-]\!] \rangle$ *be a free* $\mathcal{T}$*-model with variables from* X*, i.e.: and* $\mathrm{var} : X \to \underline{A}$.

Then:

an equation $X \vdash t \equiv u$ *is* **provable** *in* $\mathcal{T}$	$\iff$	A **validates** *it* $A[\![t]\!]\,\mathrm{var} = A[\![u]\!]\,\mathrm{var}$

NB: consequences beyond algebraic simplification

- **algebraic effects** in semantics (Plotkin and Power, 2002)
- **effect handlers** in functional programming (Bauer and Pretnar, 2015)
- **modular abstract syntax** with binding+substitution+holes (Fiore et al., 1999)

Modern algebra's core idea:

Theorem (extensional normalisation)

Let:

- $\mathcal{T}$ *be an algebraic theory;*
- $A = \langle \underline{A}, A[\![-]\!] \rangle$ *be a free* $\mathcal{T}$*-model with variables from* X*, i.e.: and* $\mathrm{var} : X \to \underline{A}$.

Then:

an equation $X \vdash t \equiv u$ *is* **provable** *in* $\mathcal{T}$	$\iff$	A **validates** *it* $A[\![t]\!]\,\mathrm{var} = A[\![u]\!]\,\mathrm{var}$

NB2: Monad connection

For $\mathbf{F}_{\mathcal{T}} X = \langle MX, [\![-]\!] \rangle$ free $\mathcal{T}$-model over X via $\mathrm{var} : X \to MX$:

- MX is a **monad** with var its unit;
- $\mathbf{F}_{\mathcal{T}} X$ are all the **algebraic effects** of it;
- $\mathcal{T}$-models are all the **effect handlers** of them.

theory of algebraic simplifiers $\xrightarrow{\text{ought to give}}$ **building blocks** for algebraic simplifiers?

Initial results (Allais et al., 2023)

- Free involutive $\mathcal{T}$-models over/extensions by X from those for $\mathcal{T}$ and Bool $\times X$
- Free $\mathcal{T}$-homomorphism graph models/extensions over X from those of $\mathcal{T}$ for all Y

This talk

distributive combinations of theories and their simplifiers

Semiring $A = \langle \underline{A}, 1, (\cdot), 0, (+) \rangle$

- monoid $\langle \underline{A}, 1, (\cdot) \rangle$ that
- **distributes** over a commutative monoid $\langle \underline{A}, 0, (+) \rangle$:

$$0 \cdot x = 0 = x \cdot 0 \qquad (x + y) \cdot z = x \cdot z + y \cdot z \qquad x \cdot (y + z) = x \cdot y + x \cdot z$$

Semi-rings are what makes matrices 'work'.

Semiring $A = \langle \underline{A}, 1, (\cdot), 0, (+) \rangle$

- monoid $\langle \underline{A}, 1, (\cdot) \rangle$ that
- **distributes** over a commutative monoid $\langle \underline{A}, 0, (+) \rangle$:

$$0 \cdot x = 0 = x \cdot 0 \qquad (x + y) \cdot z = x \cdot z + y \cdot z \qquad x \cdot (y + z) = x \cdot y + x \cdot z$$

Semi-rings are what makes matrices 'work'.

Can vary the two algebraic structures to get:

- rings, i.e., addition has inverses;
- (semi-)rings without multiplicative unit or additive zero;
- commutative (semi-)rings;
- involution over multiplication; etc.

We'll consider the general situation.

Semiring $A = \langle \underline{A}, 1, (\cdot), 0, (+) \rangle$

- monoid $\langle \underline{A}, 1, (\cdot) \rangle$ that
- **distributes** over a commutative monoid $\langle \underline{A}, 0, (+) \rangle$:

$$0 \cdot x = 0 = x \cdot 0 \qquad (x + y) \cdot z = x \cdot z + y \cdot z \qquad x \cdot (y + z) = x \cdot y + x \cdot z$$

Semi-rings are what makes matrices 'work'.

Distributive combination $(\mathcal{T} \triangleleft \mathcal{S})$-model $A = \langle \underline{A}, \mathcal{T}[\![-]\!], \mathcal{S}[\![-]\!] \rangle$

- $\mathcal{T}$-model $\langle \underline{A}, \mathcal{T}[\![-]\!] \rangle$; that
- **distributes** over an $\mathcal{S}$-model $\langle \underline{A}, \mathcal{S}[\![-]\!] \rangle$, i.e., for all:
  $\mathcal{T}$-operation $(f : n) \in \mathcal{T}$, $\mathcal{S}$-operation $(g : k)$ and position $1 \leq i \leq n$:

$$\begin{aligned} &\mathcal{T}[\![f]\!](x_1, \ldots, x_{i-1}, \mathcal{S}[\![g]\!](y_1, \ldots, y_k), x_{i+1}, \ldots, x_n) = \\ &\quad \mathcal{S}[\![g]\!](\mathcal{T}[\![f]\!](x_1, \ldots, x_{i-1}, y_1, x_{i+1}, \ldots, x_n), \ldots, \\ &\qquad \mathcal{T}[\![f]\!](x_1, \ldots, x_{i-1}, y_k, x_{i+1}, \ldots, x_n)) \end{aligned}$$

Example distributive combinations

Multiplicative structure			Additive structure		
Theory	**Comm.**[1]	**Inv.**[3]	**Comm. Semigroup**	**Comm. Monoid**	**Abelian Group**
Semigroup	**Mere**	**Mere**	$\mathcal{P}(\Sigma^+) \setminus \{\varnothing\}$	$\mathcal{P}(\Sigma^+)$	$\mathbb{Z}\langle\Sigma^+\rangle$
		Inv.[4]	$(\mathcal{P}(\Sigma^+) \setminus \{\varnothing\}, -^R)$	$(\mathcal{P}(\Sigma^+), -^R)$	$(\mathbb{Z}\langle\Sigma^+\rangle, \mathrm{rev})$
	Comm.[2]	**Mere**	$2\mathbb{N}_{>0}$	$2\mathbb{N}$	$2\mathbb{Z}$
		Inv.	$\mathfrak{m}_n^\sigma \setminus \{0\}$	$\mathfrak{m}_n^\sigma$	$(2\mathbb{Z}[\mathbf{i}], \overline{-})$
Monoid	**Mere**	**Mere**	$\mathcal{P}(\Sigma^*) \setminus \{\varnothing\}$, $M_n(\mathbb{N}_{>0})$	$\mathcal{P}(\Sigma^*)$, $M_n(\mathbb{N})$	$M_n(\mathbb{Z})$
		Inv.	$(M_n(\mathbb{N}_{>0}), -^T)$, $(\mathcal{P}(\Sigma^*) \setminus \{\varnothing\}, -^R)$	$(M_n(\mathbb{N}), -^T)$, $(\mathcal{P}(\Sigma^*), -^R)$, $\mathsf{Rel}(X)$	$(M_n(\mathbb{Z}), -^T)$
	Comm.	**Mere**	$\mathbb{N}_{>0}$	$\mathbb{N}$	$\mathbb{Z}$, $\mathbb{R}$, $\mathbb{C}$
		Inv.	$\mathbb{N}_\sigma[X_1, \ldots, X_n] \setminus \{0\}$	$\mathbb{N}_\sigma[X_1, \ldots, X_n]$	$(\mathbb{C}, \overline{-})$, $\mathbb{Z}_\sigma[X_1, \ldots, X_n]$
Group	**Mere**	**Mere**	$T_{n,\Delta_{>0}}(\mathbb{R})$	**impossible** nontrivially	**impossible** nontrivially
		Inv.	$(T_{n,\Delta_{>0}}(\mathbb{R}), -^\dagger)$	**impossible** nontrivially	**impossible** nontrivially
	Comm.	**Mere**	$\mathbb{R}_{>0}$	**impossible** nontrivially	**impossible** nontrivially
		Inv.	$(\mathbb{C}_{>0}, \overline{-})$	**impossible** nontrivially	**impossible** nontrivially

Legend: [1]Commutativity; [2]Commutative; [3]Involutivity; [4]Involutive

Theorem (Fujii et al. 2026)

For the distributive combination $\mathcal{T} \triangleleft \mathcal{S}$, if $(\mathcal{T}, \mathcal{S})$ are **compatible***:*

- *Let A be free $\mathcal{T}$-model on X; and*
- *Let B be free $\mathcal{S}$-model on $\underline{A}$.*

Then B equipped with **$\mathcal{S}$-convolution** *of A is the free $(\mathcal{T} \triangleleft \mathcal{S})$-model on X.*

giving highly modular algebraic simplifiers

Especially for rôte-proof synthesis, this theorem gives dozens of **sound-and-complete** algebraic simplifiers.
Modularity is an issue, c.f. Rocq's ecosystem:

- uses **almost rings** (Grégoire and Mahboubi, 2005)
- one algebraic structure
- incomplete, but good enough, simplifier

Theorem (Fujii et al. 2026)

For:

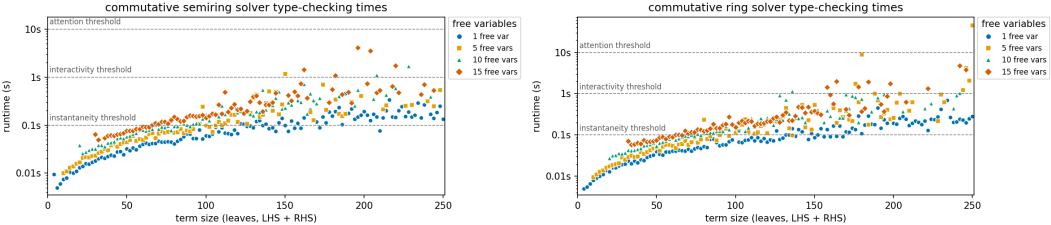
- *algebraic theory* $\mathcal{T}$*;*
- *algebraic theory* $\mathcal{S}$ *(or merely monad* $\mathcal{S}$*);*
- *set* X*;*
- *free* $\mathcal{T}$*-model* $A = \langle \underline{A}, A[\![-]\!] \rangle$ *over* X *via* $\mathrm{var}^{\mathcal{T}} : X \to \underline{A}$*;*
- *free* $\mathcal{S}$*-model* $B = \langle \underline{B}, B[\![-]\!] \rangle$ *over* $\underline{A}$ *via* $\mathrm{var}^{\mathcal{S}} : \underline{A} \to \underline{B}$

If $(\mathcal{T}, \mathcal{S})$ *are* **compatible** *then have free* $(\mathcal{T} \triangleleft \mathcal{S})$*-model over* X *by:*

$$\langle \underline{B}, \mathbf{Conv}_{\mathcal{S}} A, B[\![-]\!] \rangle \qquad X \xrightarrow{\mathrm{var}^{\mathcal{T}}} \underline{A} \xrightarrow{\mathrm{var}^{\mathcal{S}}} \underline{B}$$

where $\mathbf{Conv}_{\mathcal{S}} A$ *is the* $\mathcal{S}$**-convolution** *of* A*.*

Associated implementation doesn't suck for, e.g., responsive **type-level computation**:



Type-checking times for the commutative semiring and ring simplifiers.

Talk structure

- Introduction
- Why is it difficult?
- Generalised convolution
- Verbal substructure
- Compatibility

Known instances

$$T_{\text{semi-ring}} = T_{\text{commutative monoid}} \circ T_{\text{monoid}}$$

cf. category-theoretic concepts of **monad-monad distributive law** (Beck, 1969)

Monad-connection — notable interest for PL-semanticists

Known instances

$$T_{\text{semi-ring}} = T_{\text{commutative monoid}} \circ T_{\text{monoid}}$$

cf. category-theoretic concepts of **monad-monad distributive law** (Beck, 1969)

Monad-connection — notable interest for PL-semanticists

Impossibility results

Plotkin's counter-example (Varacca and Winskel, 2006)—**no** distributive law between

- probabilistic non-determinism: free Barycentric algebra / finite probability distribution monad
- non-determinism: free finite powerset monad

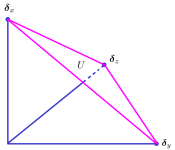
Systematically generalised by Zwart and Marsden (2022).

Distributive combination

Can be non-modular:

free (probability ◁ non-determinism)-model carried by **credal sets** (Levi, 1980):

(finitely-generated) convex subsets of probability distributions



This approach

- Pioneered by Parlant (2020); Parlant et al. (2020); Dahlqvist et al. (2018)
- Fujii et al. (2026) connect it to Tronin's (2002) **verbal categories**, making the approach general and systematic

Limitations

- Only for monads over sets, cf. Dash and Staton's (2021) distributive combination for point processes:

  probability distributions over measurable spaces
  distributes over
  multisets / commutative monoids

- **inapplicable** theory when $\mathcal{S}$ is not **commutative**/**exchangeable**

Talk structure

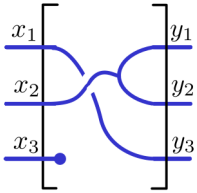
- Introduction
- Why is it difficult?
- Generalised convolution
- Verbal substructure
- Compatibility

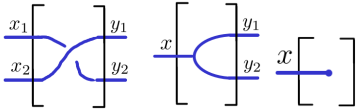
Central question

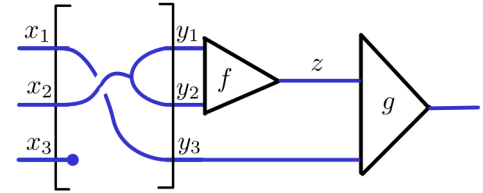
Approach

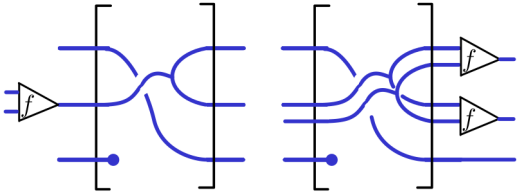
Talk structure

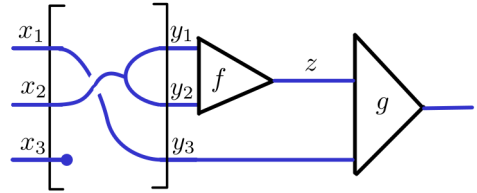
- Introduction
- Why is it difficult?
- Generalised convolution
- Verbal substructure
- Compatibility

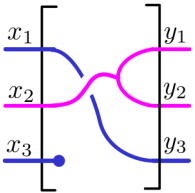

x_1
x_2
x_3
y_1
y_2
y_3

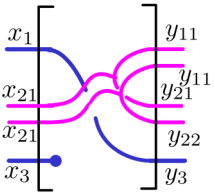

x_1
x_2
y_1
y_2
x
y_1
y_2
x


x_1
x_2
x_3
y_1
y_2
y_3
f
z
g


f
f
f


x_1
x_2
x_3
y_1
y_2
y_3
f
z
g


x_1
x_2
x_3
y_1
y_2
y_3


x_1
x_{21}
x_{21}
x_3
y_{11}
y_{11}
y_{21}
y_{22}
y_3

Examples

Talk structure

- Introduction
- Why is it difficult?
- Generalised convolution
- Verbal substructure
- Compatibility

Further work

Allais, G., Brady, E., Corbyn, N., Kammar, O., and Yallop, J. (2025). Frex: Dependently typed algebraic simplification. *Proceedings of the ACM on Programming Languages*, 9(ICFP):30–65.

Allais, G., Corbyn, N., Kammar, O., Lindley, S., Valliappan, N., and Yallop, J. (2023). Modular construction of multi-sorted free extensions. extended abstract.

Bauer, A. and Pretnar, M. (2015). Programming with algebraic effects and handlers. *Journal of Logical and Algebraic Methods in Programming*, 84(1):108–123. Special Issue: The 23rd Nordic Workshop on Programming Theory (NWPT 2011) Special Issue: Domains X, International workshop on Domain Theory and applications, Swansea, 5-7 September, 2011.

Beck, J. (1969). Distributive laws. In Eckmann, B., editor, *Seminar on Triples and Categorical Homology Theory*, pages 119–140, Berlin, Heidelberg. Springer Berlin Heidelberg.

Brown, G. (2027). *Effective Free Extensions for Languages with Binding*. PhD thesis, University of Edinburgh.

Carette, J., Kiselyov, O., and Shan, C. (2009). Finally tagless, partially evaluated: Tagless staged interpreters for simpler typed languages. *J. Funct. Program.*, 19(5):509–543.

Corbyn, N., Kammar, O., Lindley, S., Valliappan, N., and Yallop, J. (2022). Normalization by evaluation with free extensions. extended abstract.

Dahlqvist, F., Parlant, L., and Silva, A. (2018). Layer by layer – combining monads. In *Theoretical Aspects of Computing – ICTAC 2018*, volume 11187 of *Lecture Notes in Computer Science*, pages 153–172. Springer International Publishing.

Dash, S. and Staton, S. (2021). A monad for probabilistic point processes. *Electronic Proceedings in Theoretical Computer Science*, 333:19–32.

Fiore, M. P., Plotkin, G. D., and Turi, D. (1999). Abstract syntax and variable binding (extended abstract). In *Proc. 14th LICS Conf.*, pages 193–202. IEEE, Computer Society Press.

Fujii, S., Tsai, Y. C., Montacute, Y., and Hasuo, I. (2026). Monads and Distributive Laws in Substructural Contexts. In Faggian, C. and Katoen, J.-P., editors, *41st Annual Symposium on Logic in Computer Science (LICS 2026)*, volume 380 of *Leibniz International Proceedings in Informatics (LIPIcs)*, pages 45:1–45:28, Dagstuhl, Germany. Schloss Dagstuhl – Leibniz-Zentrum für Informatik.

Grégoire, B. and Mahboubi, A. (2005). Proving equalities in a commutative ring done right in coq. In Hurd, J. and Melham, T., editors, *Theorem Proving in Higher Order Logics*, pages 98–113, Berlin, Heidelberg. Springer Berlin Heidelberg.

Levi, I. (1980). *The Enterprise of Knowledge: An Essay on Knowledge, Credal Probability, and Chance*. MIT Press.

Parlant, L. (2020). *Monad Composition via Preservation of Algebras*. PhD thesis, University College London.

Parlant, L., Rot, J., Silva, A., and Westerbaan, B. (2020). Preservation of Equations by Monoidal Monads. In Esparza, J. and Král', D., editors, *45th International Symposium on Mathematical Foundations of Computer Science (MFCS 2020)*, volume 170 of *Leibniz International Proceedings in Informatics (LIPIcs)*, pages 77:1–77:14, Dagstuhl, Germany. Schloss Dagstuhl – Leibniz-Zentrum für Informatik.

Plotkin, G. and Power, J. (2002). Notions of computation determine monads. In Nielsen, M. and Engberg, U., editors, *Foundations of Software Science and Computation Structures*, pages 342–356, Berlin, Heidelberg. Springer Berlin Heidelberg.

Shepherd, Z., Kammar, O., and Polgreen, E. (2026). Nsync: Normalised synthesis of computation.

Tronin, S. (2002). Abstract clones and operads. *Siberian Mathematical Journal*, 43(4):746–755.

Varacca, D. and Winskel, G. (2006). Distributing probability over non-determinism. *Mathematical Structures in Computer Science*, 16(1):87–113.

Yallop, J., van Glabbeek, T., and Kammar, O. (2019). Partially static data as free extension of algebras. *Proc. ACM Program. Lang.*, 2(ICFP).